

Introduction to Philosophy on One Sheet

The big questions, the best-known answers, and the sources behind them

PUBLIC DOMAIN

A one-semester course on two sides. Each card asks one big question and gives the best-known answers. Key terms are in bold. Small numbers point to the sources on the back.

∴ How to Think: Arguments

1

LOGIC: THE STUDY OF GOOD REASONING

Philosophy means asking big questions and giving reasons for your answers. In Plato's account of his trial, Socrates said that an unexamined life is not worth living.¹ An **argument** is a set of reasons, called **premises**, that support a conclusion. An argument is **valid** if the conclusion must be true whenever the premises are true. It is **sound** if it is valid and the premises really are true. To test an argument, look for a false premise or a gap in the logic.

👁 What We Can Know

2

EPISTEMOLOGY: THE STUDY OF KNOWLEDGE

Descartes asked if anything is beyond doubt. He imagined a powerful trickster fooling him about everything, but he could not doubt that he was thinking.² Hume noted that we expect the future to match the past, yet we cannot prove that it will.³ For a long time, knowledge was defined as **justified true belief**, which means believing something true for good reasons. In 1963, Gettier described cases where a belief is justified and true only by luck, so it does not seem to be knowledge.⁴ Philosophers still disagree about what knowledge requires.

🧠 Mind and Self

3

PHILOSOPHY OF MIND: MINDS AND SELVES

Descartes argued that the mind and the body are two different kinds of thing. This view is called **dualism**.² **Physicalism** is the view that everything is physical. Nagel argued that a full physical description of a bat still seems to leave out what it is like to be a bat.⁵ Chalmers called this puzzle the **hard problem of consciousness**: why does activity in the brain come with felt experience at all?⁶ Locke said you stay the same person over time through memory and awareness, not through having the same body.⁷

⚖ Free Will

4

METAPHYSICS: WHAT REALITY IS LIKE

Determinism is the claim that earlier events and the laws of nature fix everything that happens later. Does that leave room for free will? In this debate, **libertarians** say we have free will, so determinism must be false. **Hard determinists** say determinism is true, so we lack free will.

Compatibilists say both can be true. Hume argued that acting freely means acting on your own wishes without being forced.³ Frankfurt described cases where a person could not have done otherwise, yet still seems responsible for the choice.⁸

👤 God and Evil

5

PHILOSOPHY OF RELIGION: THINKING ABOUT GOD

Aquinas gave five arguments for the existence of God. One of them reasons from chains of causes back to a first cause.⁹ The **problem of evil** asks how a God who is all-powerful and all-good could allow suffering. Mackie argued that three claims cannot all be true: God is all-powerful, God is all-good, and evil exists.¹⁰ Defenders of belief reply in many ways. One reply is that a world with free choices is worth the risk that some people will choose evil.

⚖ Right and Wrong

6

ETHICS: WHAT IS RIGHT AND WRONG

Three main theories explain what makes acts right. **Virtue ethics** says to build good character, such as courage, which sits between cowardice and recklessness.¹¹ **Deontology** says some acts are required or forbidden. Kant said to act only on rules you could want everyone to follow.¹²

Consequentialism says the right act produces the best results. Mill's version, **utilitarianism**, counts overall happiness.¹³ Trolley cases test the theories. Should you switch a runaway trolley to kill one person instead of five? Should you push a large man off a bridge to stop it?¹⁴

Justice and Government

7

POLITICAL PHILOSOPHY: RIGHTS AND POWER

Why should anyone obey a government? Hobbes said that life with no government would mean constant fear, so people give up some freedom to a ruler in return for safety.¹⁵ Locke said people have natural rights to life, liberty, and property, and a government that violates them can lose its authority.¹⁶ Rawls asked which rules we would choose if we did not know our own place in society. He called this test the **veil of ignorance**. He argued that we would choose equal basic liberties and protect the people who are worst off.¹⁷

What Professional Philosophers Say

Views of philosophers in the 2020 PhilPapers Survey

Question	Answers, most common first
Outside world	Real and knowable (non-skeptical realism) 80% , idealism (reality is mental) 7% , skepticism (we cannot know) 5%
Free will	Compatibilism 59% , libertarianism 19% , no free will 11%
God	Atheism (no God) 67% , theism (a God) 19%
Mind	Physicalism 52% , non-physicalism (the mind is not only physical) 32%
Right and wrong	Virtue ethics 37% , deontology 32% , consequentialism 31%
Trolley: switch?	Switch 63% , do not switch 13%

Source: Bourget and Chalmers.¹⁸ 1,785 philosophy faculty answered, about 23% of the 7,685 targeted. The survey focused on English-speaking countries. Percentages include those who lean toward a view. Totals are under 100% because some chose other answers. These numbers show where philosophers lean, not what is true.

Sources

Classic works are cited by original date and standard section numbers, so any edition works. Journal names are written in full. Where a page range could not be confirmed, a digital object identifier (DOI), which is a permanent link, is given.

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